On the Wrong Stump

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 2, Episode 3

Several stumps surrounded the creek landing. Nib climbed the tallest and raised one paw in triumph. From there he could see the reeds, the roof of Reed Hut, and very little of the low pot beside the path. All three invitations still rested in his courier bag.

“I am on the top,” Nib announced grandly. “We need the pot,” Lark replied patiently.

Lark opened an earlier journal page on a flat, dry surface. Nib steadied its lower corner. One familiar word waited for another look.

“Try our earlier word before we start,” Lark invited gently. “You can sound it out or ask for help.”

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“Here is lowercase o,” Lark explained clearly. “Its short sound begins on and sits in the middle of pot. Listen: /o/. It is different from the short i in pit. Put p and t around each vowel, and hear how the word changes.”

“Join the parts and check the whole meaning,” Lark invited gently. “You can hear a part again whenever you want.”

On a little practice strip, you could try on, pot, top, nod. Lark supplied unfamiliar story names herself. Nib waited while you looked right through each word.

“Our route key names pot,” Lark invited gently. “Read pot and pit, then choose the marker the note actually names.”

A short passage stayed in view. Lark paired each needed capital with its lowercase form and familiar sound before you began, leaving the sentence meanings for you to discover.

“Read the sentences in order,” Lark invited gently. “Let your finger follow if it helps. When you are ready, use the words to answer our question.”

Dan sat on top. Sam did not.

“Who sat on top in that little passage?” Lark asked gently. “Find the name in the first sentence.”

Lark kept the passage open so you could point to the part that helped. Nib listened before adding the picture.

Lark lifted the pot from its low stump. Beneath its base lay a folded crossing note. She read its longer words aloud: the creek handrail needed fastening before the crew crossed. Nib climbed down from his excellent viewing stump. The useful information had been lower than his nose all along. They replaced the pot and walked to the repair shelter.

“Let's keep a written clue,” Lark suggested warmly. “Write o beside our picture. You can look at the example, follow it first, or try your own version. Then reread what you made.”

Lark drew the low pot and its hidden note. Across the creek, Reed Hut waited. The first invitation was still undelivered, but now the crew knew what needed doing before they reached it.